fought for ‘liberation’, but it was Prabhakaran who had split from them and formed the LTTE, declaring war against the Sri Lankan government. He had inducted teenagers and given them guns and grenades. And he hated Rajiv Gandhi for signing the Indo-Sri Lanka Accord with President Jayawardene. Karan, however, suggested that Verma not get carried away. Verma had asked his boss point-blank, ‘Sir, I want to join the SIT.’ Karan had turned him down, saying he could not let the staff run his office, but Verma had reminded him there was no dearth of officers wanting to join the office of the CBI director. He had asked Karan to consider his credentials—that he was a Tamil Nadu-cadre IPS, that he spoke fluent Tamil, knew the state like the back of his hand and that he had deep knowledge of the LTTE’s functioning. Also that he definitely wanted to thrash those who had killed the former Prime Minister. After giving it thought, Karan had called his deputy, Datta, from the car phone and asked his opinion of Verma even as the latter sat beside him. It didn’t take more than a minute for Verma to be inducted into the SIT.

Sub-editor Binoo John came rushing in with the fax copy of Shekhar’s story from Madras. Oh god, he had already started filing. Anirudhya tried to sneak a look at the copy. But John said, ‘A reporter could not peep into a senior editor’s copy, sorry.’ All Anirudhya could manage to see were two more bylines next to Shekhar’s—Anand Viswanathan and Kavitha Shetty. He knew they were both from *India Today*’s Madras bureau.

Anirudhya looked across the newsroom. Bobb’s cabin was diagonally across from him. He had set the deadline at six. And no one messed with Bobb’s deadlines. He asked Bobb if he had to file his copy that evening since the story was not meant for publication the next morning, *India Today* being a fortnightly and not a daily. If Anirudhya had come to the magazine with the reputation of being a Page One reporter, Bobb was a prima donna who had been there since its inception and was credited with setting up the magazine’s style of writing.

Bobb was sunk in piles of computer printouts. He looked up and asked with a poker face if Anirudhya could file by six. The editors in office knew